

Weekly Reading Reflections #10: Sergio Monterroso

Digital History Reflection

Importance of Digital History

The U.S. Civil Rights Cold Case Records Review Board (such brevity) maintains a digital record of cases in the civil rights era involving Black Americans being killed on account of their race. Each case features a photograph of the deceased victim, their story on how they were attacked, and related records like coroner inquest reports. The records are maintained by the National Archives and Records Administration which helps with this project. Their link is <https://www.coldcaserecords.gov/>.

If a person wanted to reach similar conclusions using records from NARA, they would have to do their own research to compile all the documents available to them. Sometimes, accessibility is difficult, and I have no doubt that some of these records could only be made available to professional historians instead of a historically curious individual looking to see the cold cases of the civil rights era. Accessibility is best served by digital record compilations like the Civil Rights Cold Case website.

Accessibility does not only help website visitors find information easier, but it is also helpful even to researchers like me. In my project, I used many images and documents from NARA, the Georgia Archives, and from our own UNG archives (but those were physical documents). Without these databases, historical research would be limited to places like Washington D.C. where the archives are kept. Part of me wonders how history used to be taught in places like UNG before digitization came: did professors just rely on textbooks to give them information instead of looking at the records themselves? How can we call that history? I may sound spoiled, but I am glad to live in the era that I do. Still, we continue to have issues with digitizing information. Dr. Bush conducted months of research to compile data, so is it right for her to share it online for others to steal it? Can information be stolen? Obviously, it depends on the person, but I guess I would understand a data researcher that would want to hide their data that took years to compile behind a paywall. These are concerns that digital historians are going to have to confront in the future years.

In the past, we talked about the different pedagogies of museums: the laboratory, the pyramid, and the cube. Reflecting on digital history made me realize that this can be applied to digital history: it's the laboratory like the postmodern museum that we discussed that week. Here, the information is laid out and, while there is a clear message attached to the text, it is not hammered down like the modern museum's patriarchal method of teaching instead of educating. But now I wonder, can there be a digital history project that does not follow the postmodern method? More research would have to be done but I guess it depends on the message and conduct of the project: like a blog from an old history professor where he just gives his teaching instead of records... but is that digital history for our purposes? If not, then does postmodernist pedagogy a requirement to be digital history? These questions are interesting, and I have a digital history class with Dr. Bush in the fall, which I hope to bring these questions up at.

Applicability to Project

My project involves a physical museum location, and though digital history helps spread accessibility of a project and its compiled research, it also can be dangerous to a project if it is unnecessarily digitized, according to Dr. Bush. For my project, it is unnecessary to digitize something that can be better served in a physical catalogue handed out prior to coming to a museum instead of asking visitors (especially in a museum that caters to older audiences) to scan a QR code or visit a website. There is a technological gap between the purpose of my project and my audience that makes digitizing my project unnecessary.